

D449

Psychiatric and Mental Health Nursing

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer _____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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Items

1.

On an inpatient unit with a garden courtyard, a nurse meets a newly admitted 35-year-old patient for the first time. The patient, a software tester, wants to talk about his divorce right away. What is the nurse's main task in this phase?

- A. Review his progress and plan for ending the relationship.
- B. Promise to keep everything he says secret.
- C. Help him work through his feelings about the divorce.
- D. Establish trust and agree on the purpose, schedule, and limits of confidentiality.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

As discharge nears, a patient who has worked well with the nurse becomes irritable and misses sessions. Which phase is the relationship in?

- A. Pre-orientation
- B. Termination
- C. Orientation
- D. Working

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A 50-year-old with major depression, who once ran a flower shop and whose daughter calls every night, has been withdrawn for a week. Today he seems calm and gives his watch to a roommate. What should the nurse do?

- A. Note that his mood has improved.
- B. Ask him directly whether he is thinking of killing himself and whether he has a plan.
- C. Call his daughter to ask how he seemed on the phone.
- D. Avoid mentioning suicide so the idea is not planted.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A patient with bipolar disorder, who plays guitar in a band and recently switched jobs, has had vomiting and diarrhea for two days and now has a coarse hand tremor. Her lithium level is 1.8 mEq/L. What should the nurse do?

- A. Give an antidiarrheal and continue lithium.
- B. Encourage a low-sodium diet to protect her kidneys.
- C. Hold the lithium and notify the provider.
- D. Give the next dose; the level is within range.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which change is most likely to raise a patient's lithium level?

- A. Adding more salt to food
- B. Taking lithium with meals
- C. Dehydration from heavy sweating on a hot day
- D. Drinking more water

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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6.

Four days after starting haloperidol, a patient who used to work as a chef and enjoys cooking shows has a temperature of 40 °C (104 °F), stiff muscles, sweating, and confusion. His BP is swinging widely. His brother visited yesterday. What is the most likely problem?

- A. Tardive dyskinesia
- B. Anxiety from the family visit
- C. An expected side effect to monitor
- D. Neuroleptic malignant syndrome, a medical emergency

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A patient who has taken an antipsychotic for many years has repeated lip smacking and tongue thrusting but no fever. What is this most likely to be?

- A. Tardive dyskinesia
- B. Neuroleptic malignant syndrome
- C. Acute dystonia
- D. Alcohol withdrawal

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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8.

A 45-year-old contractor admitted for a broken wrist had his last drink 56 hours ago. He is now confused, sees bugs on the wall, and has a heart rate of 128. He drinks a six-pack daily and his wife says he is a hard worker. What is happening?

- A.** Delirium tremens, a medical emergency needing benzodiazepines and close monitoring
- B.** Withdrawal is over by 48 hours, so this must be a new problem
- C.** Mild early withdrawal that will pass
- D.** Pain from his wrist fracture

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A patient with borderline personality disorder, who writes poetry and has a pet rabbit at home, tells the day nurse, “You’re the only one who understands me — the night nurses are terrible.” What is the best response?

- A.** Make a special exception to her unit rules this once.
- B.** Report the night nurses for being unkind.
- C.** Agree to handle all her care personally.
- D.** Keep the same limits as the rest of the team and address concerns in the shared care plan.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A 19-year-old college swimmer with anorexia nervosa, whose parents flew in from out of state, is on day 3 of nutrition therapy. She reports new weakness and her heart rate is irregular. Which lab is most important to check?

- A.** Serum sodium
- B.** No labs; she needs more calories faster
- C.** Serum phosphorus
- D.** Hemoglobin A1c

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

An 80-year-old retired judge, who does the crossword every day, became confused yesterday and today cannot focus on a conversation. Her confusion comes and goes, and she has a new urinary tract infection. Her daughter says she was sharp last week. What is most likely?

- A.** Delirium, likely from the infection
- B.** Dementia, because she is 80
- C.** Normal aging
- D.** Depression

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Over three years, a patient’s memory has slowly declined. He is alert and can focus in conversation but cannot recall recent events. What is most likely?

- A.** Delirium
- B.** Dementia
- C.** An acute infection
- D.** Alcohol withdrawal

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

On an inpatient unit ~~with a garden courtyard~~, a nurse meets a newly admitted 35-year-old patient for the first time. The patient, ~~a software tester~~, wants to talk about his divorce right away. What is the nurse's main task in this phase?

Target word: task of the first phase **Decides:** First meeting = orientation.

A	Adjacent category	That is the termination phase.
B	Absolute language	Confidentiality has limits, such as safety risks.
C	Inverted operation	Problem-solving belongs in the working phase.
D	Correct	Orientation builds the base for later work.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

As discharge nears, a patient who has worked well with the nurse becomes irritable and misses sessions. Which phase is the relationship in?

Target word: reverse: from behavior to phase **Decides:** Reactions to the relationship ending.

A	Confusion set	The nurse's preparation before meeting the patient.
B	Correct	Anger or withdrawal is common as the relationship ends.
C	Inverted operation	The first phase, not the last.
D	Adjacent category	The problem-solving middle phase.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A 50-year-old with major depression, ~~who once ran a flower shop and whose daughter calls every night~~, has been withdrawn for a week. Today he seems calm and gives his watch to a roommate. What should the nurse do?

Target word: respond to warning signs **Decides:** Sudden calm + giving away belongings = possible suicide plan.

A	Inverted operation	Sudden calm can mean a decision to act.
B	Correct	Direct questions assess risk and do not increase it.
C	Camouflage	Uses the daughter detail and delays asking the patient.
D	Absolute language	Asking does not create the idea.

4. Answer C Concept 3

A patient with bipolar disorder, ~~who plays guitar in a band and recently switched jobs~~, has had vomiting and diarrhea for two days and now has a coarse hand tremor. Her lithium level is 1.8 mEq/L. What should the nurse do?

Target word: act on lithium level **Decides:** 1.8 is above the toxic threshold of about 1.5.

A	Dropped element	Drops the level that explains the GI symptoms.
B	Inverted operation	Low sodium raises lithium levels further.
C	Correct	The level and symptoms show toxicity.
D	Wrong stem number	1.8 is above the 0.6–1.2 range.

5. Answer C Concept 3 · transfer

Which change is most likely to raise a patient's lithium level?

Target word: reverse: from level to cause **Decides:** Lithium rises with fluid or sodium loss.

A	Adjacent category	Higher sodium tends to lower lithium levels.
B	Confusion set	Food timing affects stomach upset, not level in this way.
C	Correct	Less fluid and sodium lets the kidneys hold on to lithium.
D	Inverted operation	Good hydration helps keep levels steady.

6. Answer D Concept 4

Four days after starting haloperidol, a patient ~~who used to work as a chef and enjoys cooking shows~~ has a temperature of 40 °C (104 °F), stiff muscles, sweating, and confusion. His BP is swinging widely. ~~His brother visited yesterday.~~ What is the most likely problem?

Target word: identify syndrome **Decides:** Fever + rigidity + altered mental status on an antipsychotic = NMS.

A	Confusion set	A late movement disorder without fever.
B	Camouflage	Leans on the visit detail.
C	Absolute language	This pattern is life-threatening.
D	Correct	The classic signs call for stopping the drug and urgent care.

7. Answer A Concept 4 · transfer

A patient who has taken an antipsychotic for many years has repeated lip smacking and tongue thrusting but no fever. What is this most likely to be?

Target word: reverse: pick TD **Decides:** Late involuntary face and tongue movements.

A	Correct	A late movement disorder from long-term use.
B	Confusion set	NMS has fever and rigidity and appears early.
C	Adjacent category	Sudden muscle spasm, usually in the first days.
D	Inverted operation	Unrelated to long-term antipsychotic use.

8. Answer A Concept 5

A 45-year-old contractor admitted for a broken wrist had his last drink 56 hours ago. He is now confused, sees bugs on the wall, and has a heart rate of 128. He drinks a six-pack daily and ~~his wife says he is a hard worker.~~ What is happening?

Target word: stage of withdrawal **Decides:** About 48-72 hours after the last drink with confusion and hallucinations = delirium tremens.

A	Correct	Timing and symptoms match DTs.
B	Absolute language	DTs peak in the 48-72-hour window.
C	Inverted operation	Early withdrawal starts within the first day and is milder.
D	Camouflage	Leans on the admission reason.

9. Answer D Concept 6

A patient with borderline personality disorder, ~~who writes poetry and has a pet rabbit at home~~, tells the day nurse, "You're the only one who understands me — the night nurses are terrible." What is the best response?

Target word: respond to splitting **Decides:** Consistent limits from the whole team.

A	Absolute language	Exceptions undo the shared limits.
B	Inverted operation	Acts on the split instead of addressing it.
C	Confusion set	Accepting the "good nurse" role feeds splitting.
D	Correct	Consistency blocks splitting.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A 19-year-old ~~college swimmer~~ with anorexia nervosa, ~~whose parents flew in from out of state~~, is on day 3 of nutrition therapy. She reports new weakness and her heart rate is irregular. Which lab is most important to check?

Target word: lab for refeeding syndrome **Decides:** Refeeding drops phosphorus.

A	Adjacent category	Can change but is not the hallmark finding.
B	Inverted operation	Faster refeeding worsens the syndrome.
C	Correct	Low phosphorus is the hallmark of refeeding syndrome.
D	Confusion set	A long-term diabetes marker.

11. Answer A Concept 8

An 80-year-old retired judge, ~~who does the crossword every day~~, became confused yesterday and today cannot focus on a conversation. Her confusion comes and goes, and she has a new urinary tract infection. Her daughter says she was sharp last week. What is most likely?

Target word: delirium vs. dementia **Decides:** Sudden onset + fluctuating attention + an infection.

A	Correct	Acute onset and poor attention point to delirium with a treatable cause.
B	Confusion set	Age alone does not make it dementia; onset was sudden.
C	Absolute language	Sudden confusion is never normal aging.
D	Adjacent category	Can mimic cognitive decline but does not fluctuate with a new infection.

12. Answer B Concept 8 · transfer

Over three years, a patient's memory has slowly declined. He is alert and can focus in conversation but cannot recall recent events. What is most likely?

Target word: reverse: pick dementia **Decides:** Gradual decline with intact attention.

A	Inverted operation	Delirium is sudden and affects attention.
B	Correct	Slow, steady decline over years with intact alertness.
C	Dropped element	Drops the three-year timeline.
D	Confusion set	Causes acute symptoms, not years of decline.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	2	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	6	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	10	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	8	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Phases of the nurse-client relationship	Orientation builds trust and sets the contract and limits of confidentiality; working addresses problems and new coping; termination reviews progress and feelings about ending.	Starting problem-solving in the first meeting or ignoring feelings at the end.	First meeting, middle sessions, or approaching discharge.
2	Suicide risk assessment	Ask directly and clearly about suicidal thoughts, plan, and means; asking does not plant the idea, and sudden calm or giving away belongings can signal a decision.	Avoiding the word “suicide” or treating sudden calm as recovery.	A depressed patient with a behavior change or a hint about ending things.
3	Lithium safety	Lithium’s therapeutic range is narrow (about 0.6–1.2 mEq/L); levels above about 1.5 cause vomiting, diarrhea, coarse tremor, and confusion; dehydration and low sodium raise levels.	Thinking a small rise over the range is harmless or that cutting salt is healthy on lithium.	A lithium level, GI upset, tremor, or a change in fluid or salt intake.
4	Neuroleptic malignant syndrome vs. tardive dyskinesia	NMS is an acute emergency on antipsychotics: high fever, severe muscle rigidity, altered mental status, unstable vital signs. Tardive dyskinesia is a late, often lasting movement disorder of the face and tongue.	Calling fever and rigidity a movement side effect, or TD an emergency.	An antipsychotic plus fever and rigidity, or plus lip smacking after long use.
5	Alcohol withdrawal timeline	Withdrawal starts about 6–24 hours after the last drink; delirium tremens (confusion, hallucinations, unstable vital signs) usually appears 48–72 hours after and is an emergency treated with benzodiazepines.	Believing the danger is over after the first day.	Hours since the last drink plus new confusion or tremors.
6	Borderline personality: splitting	Patients who split staff into “all good” and “all bad” need consistent limits applied by the whole team and one shared plan.	Accepting the role of the “good” nurse or making exceptions for one patient.	A patient praises one nurse and criticizes the others.
7	Refeeding syndrome	When nutrition restarts after starvation, phosphorus, potassium, and magnesium can drop sharply, causing weakness and heart problems; feed slowly and watch labs.	Thinking faster refeeding is better or that weakness means she needs more calories.	An eating disorder patient in the first days of refeeding with new weakness.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
8	Delirium vs. dementia	Delirium develops over hours to days, fluctuates, impairs attention, and usually has a treatable cause; dementia develops over months to years with steady decline.	Labeling any confusion in an older adult as dementia.	Onset timing and whether attention is affected.

Course scope (public description): Psychiatric and Mental Health Nursing prepares students to provide safe, equitable, high-quality care using modern concepts of psychiatric and mental health nursing. The student will utilize therapeutic communication to a diverse population of patients including those with maladaptive behaviors through the utilization of the nursing process by applying the principles of psychiatric and mental healthcare and the clinical judgement model. This course explores the nurse-client relationship, pharmacological management, cognitive conditions, bipolar and thought conditions, personality disorders, substance abuse, eating disorders, and self-harm. A variety of populations and settings are used in the experiential learning components of this course. Co-requisites: D450. Prerequisite Courses: All prelicensure nursing curriculum courses from previous terms and D445.